

# AI, the Overman, and the Last Man: Nietzsche's Human Future in the Age of Artificial Intelligence

## Introduction

As artificial intelligence systems become more sophisticated, public discourse has revived nineteenth-century dreams about “supermen” and human evolution. Venture capitalists such as SoftBank's Masayoshi Son have hailed ChatGPT as the “*birth of superhuman*,” claiming that AI will produce hundreds of inventions and elevate humanity to a new stage of evolution <sup>1</sup>. Designers and technologists speak of **cognitive orchestrators** that will integrate many agents and usher in an *interstellar species* <sup>2</sup>. In such accounts, artificial intelligence (AI) itself seems to be the long-awaited answer to Friedrich Nietzsche's call for a new type of human being.

Yet Nietzsche's concept of the **Übermensch** or *Overman* is rooted in a unique philosophical problem: how to live after the death of God. In *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* he declares that humanity is “*a rope, fastened between animal and Superman — a rope over an abyss*”, and what is great in humankind is that it is a bridge rather than an end <sup>3</sup>. The Overman is the one who crosses this rope by overcoming nihilism, creating values, and affirming life, whereas the *Last Man* is the comfortable, complacent figure who refuses challenge and shrugs at deeper meaning. The modern question “What if the Overman is AI?” misreads Nietzsche if it treats the Overman as a technological artefact rather than a human transformation. The following paper argues that AI cannot be the Overman because it lacks will, suffering, and value-creation, yet AI can become a decisive test for humanity: it may empower us toward self-overcoming, or it may seduce us into Last-Man passivity. The outcome depends less on AI's capabilities than on how humans respond to them.

## 1. Nietzsche's Overman and Last Man

### 1.1 The Image of the Rope

Nietzsche introduced the Overman in the Prologue of *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, describing humanity as a *rope over an abyss*. This metaphor ties together three key insights. First, it portrays the human being as transitional rather than finished; we are neither merely animals nor yet our own highest possibility. Second, it highlights the precariousness of the human condition: the abyss of meaninglessness looms beneath. Third, it implies movement and risk; standing still on the rope is not an option. Zarathustra urges: “Man is something that should be overcome. What have you done to overcome him?” The Overman is thus not simply a stronger or smarter being, but the result of *self-overcoming*.

### 1.2 Self-Overcoming and Value Creation

In Nietzsche's later works, the term *Übermensch* fades in favour of “higher types,” “future philosophers,” and “legislators of values.” Across these terms, the Overman designates a person who overcomes nihilism by creating new values. Rather than clinging to inherited moralities, this figure embodies the **will to power** – not a hunger for domination but a fundamental drive to form, interpret, and give meaning. As one

contemporary essay notes, the Overman is an individual who creates their own meaning, fully affirms life, and continually strives to reach their fullest potential. Such striving entails discipline, suffering and joyful creativity: Nietzsche describes the “three metamorphoses” of the spirit (camel, lion, child), culminating in the child who says a creative “Yes” to life.

### 1.3 The Last Man

Nietzsche juxtaposes the Overman with the **Last Man**, a warning figure who values comfort and safety above growth. In *Zarathustra* he imagines the Last Men asking, “*What is love? What is creation? What is longing?*” and blinking, content with small pleasures. Such people avoid risk and therefore cannot be bridges to anything higher. An article on user-experience design captures this dynamic, noting that modern products often anticipate users’ needs, narrow their choices and remove all effort, thereby teaching users to expect less of themselves <sup>4</sup>. Nietzsche’s concern was not simply that people would be unhappy, but that they would lose the very capacity for creating values and transcending themselves.

## 2. Modern Appropriations: Superman and Transhumanism

### 2.1 Superman in Pop Culture

After Nietzsche’s death, the idea of a superhuman re-appeared in popular culture. The Fortune magazine article on AI and superhumans notes that DC Comics’ *Superman* debuted in 1939 during an age of skyscrapers and industrial marvels <sup>5</sup>. The comic character could leap tall buildings and was physically superior to the ordinary human <sup>6</sup>. Yet this superhero retains moral infallibility: he is a paragon of virtue, reinforcing rather than subverting common values <sup>7</sup>. The pop-culture Superman thus conflates the Overman with a physically enhanced saviour rather than a radical value creator. As Fortune observes, the notion of a superhuman has often intersected with transhumanism—the idea that technology will enable humans to transform themselves and overcome physical limitations <sup>8</sup>. These associations have been misused by political movements such as communism and fascism, which co-opted the ideal of a “new man” and linked it to race or eugenics <sup>9</sup>.

### 2.2 Transhumanism and the New Industrial Revolution

The conversation about superhumans has re-emerged with the **Fourth Industrial Revolution** – an age of smart automation and artificial intelligence <sup>10</sup>. Fortune notes that investors and technologists now ask what new aspirational icon will transcend the power frameworks of our time <sup>10</sup>. Some, like Masayoshi Son, proclaim AI itself to be the new Übermensch, insisting that his company will use AI to invent hundreds of new technologies and even design “the future of humanity” <sup>1</sup>. This narrative is not confined to venture capital; transhumanist authors imagine a future in which humans merge with machines or upload their minds to computers. In such accounts, the Overman is reinterpreted as an enhancement of cognitive power rather than a change in our relationship to values.

### 2.3 Reactionary Fantasies and Political Misuse

Other contemporary discourses twist Nietzsche for reactionary or accelerationist purposes. A 2024 Harvard Divinity Bulletin article shows how far-right movements like “effective accelerationism” and internet provocateurs romanticize the Overman as a justification for technological acceleration and social Darwinism <sup>11</sup>. Meanwhile, “Bronze Age Pervert” style internet communities use pseudo-Nietzschean rhetoric to

celebrate physical strength and chauvinism <sup>12</sup>. Such misreadings ignore Nietzsche's emphasis on spiritual transformation and thus risk replicating the violent misuses of his work in the twentieth century.

### 3. AI as Overman? – Claims and Hype

#### 3.1 Hype in Tech Circles

Proponents of AI often portray the technology as a path to human transcendence. SoftBank's Son described his existential crisis upon encountering ChatGPT and then embraced AI as a way to “design the future of humanity” <sup>1</sup>. The Fortune article notes that the idea of AI as superhuman arises whenever society undergoes rapid technological change <sup>10</sup>. Transhumanists argue that AI will cure diseases, extend human lifespans, and even enable us to live for 300 years. They depict AI as an engine of abundance that will eliminate poverty and free us to pursue our creative projects, fulfilling the Overman's supposed dreams.

From the perspective of computer scientists and entrepreneurs, AI systems that surpass human performance on cognitive tasks could be seen as *overcoming* humanity. In one sense, large language models and multi-agent orchestration frameworks already surpass our capacity to process information. LinkedIn writer Suresh Surenthiran claims that in the “multidimensional technological era” humanity is redesigning itself through AI and systemic automation, creating a new ascended consciousness <sup>13</sup>. He portrays the Overman as a **cognitive orchestrator** who integrates recursive intelligence systems, expands human capability and leads the species toward interstellar existence <sup>2</sup>. Such rhetoric casts AI not merely as a tool but as the embodiment of the Overman.

#### 3.2 Misidentifying the Overman with AI

These hyperbolic claims rest on an equivocation: they conflate greater computational power or extended lifespan with self-overcoming. In Nietzsche's thought, the Overman is not simply a being with superior abilities; he is the creator of new values. A technical artefact, however complex, lacks agency; it does not suffer, desire or affirm. The *Overman* is a human who has learned to live without metaphysical crutches and to affirm the earth, whereas AI is created by humans and thus depends on human goals and training. Participants on a science forum have pointed out that even if AI appears to have desires, it would simply be an amalgam of human desires from its training data, lacking genuine self-directed purpose <sup>14</sup>. Without a capacity for self-determined valuation and affirmation of existence, AI cannot cross the abyss on its own. Thus, to call AI the Overman is to misapply a metaphor to an entity that does not fit its defining criteria.

### 4. Ontological and Ethical Differences

#### 4.1 Will, Suffering, and Amor Fati

The Overman requires a **will to power** that goes beyond instrumentality. Nietzsche's will is not the desire to dominate others but the creative and interpretive drive that constitutes life. AI systems, by contrast, operate under goal functions encoded by humans; they do not experience desire or the compulsion to grow. Without suffering and struggle, there can be no amor fati – the love of fate – that Nietzsche saw as essential to the highest type. AI may simulate affective responses, but simulation is not experience. It cannot joyfully say “Yes” to its own existence because there is no *someone* within to say it.

## 4.2 Value Creation vs Value Optimization

AI excels at optimizing given objectives. It can predict, classify and generate text by maximizing the probability of tokens. But the Overman does not optimize an existing metric; he creates a new table of values. Value creation is not a computational process but an interpretive act that reconfigures the world and self. Without a prior will to power, AI cannot spontaneously devise new value frameworks. Even algorithms that appear to discover novel strategies, such as reinforcement learning agents in games, operate under reward functions humans define.

## 4.3 Agency and Responsibility

Furthermore, attributing overman status to AI risks shirking human responsibility. If we say that AI is the Overman, we implicitly absolve ourselves of the task of self-overcoming. The **Last Man** emerges when people outsource judgment, creation and meaning to technology, shrinking their will. One technology writer warns that *the Superman seems to be moving out of the embodied human experience and into the Machine Mind*, and thus the ideal of the Superman could die when it is off-loaded to a disembodied AI. Another remark notes that some forms of AI design teach users to expect less of themselves <sup>4</sup>. Nietzsche would see this as the height of decadence.

# 5. AI as Instrument: Empowerment vs Passivity

## 5.1 Designing for Last Men or Overmen

Although AI cannot itself be the Overman, it can play a role in humanity's journey across the rope. The design of AI systems influences whether they foster **Last Man** passivity or **Overman** growth. A UX analysis based on Nietzsche argues that many AI products reduce friction so effectively that they remove users' sense of involvement <sup>4</sup>. One-click actions, auto-generated content and predictive interfaces make experiences convenient but passive. The article asks whether such products may inadvertently teach users to avoid challenge and expect the machine to think for them <sup>4</sup>. By contrast, empowering AI designs keep the user actively involved: for example, Photoshop's AI features suggest edits but still allow users to adjust parameters, compare options and decide the final result <sup>15</sup>. Users shape the outcome and gain new skills, experiencing *self-overcoming* in a small way.

## 5.2 AI as Cognitive Prosthesis

AI can also serve as a **cognitive prosthesis**, augmenting human capabilities while leaving value creation to the human. In education, for instance, AI tutors can provide personalized feedback that helps learners reflect and grow rather than simply giving answers. In creative work, AI generators can propose variations or structures that inspire but do not predetermine the author's vision. When properly designed, AI becomes a tool that extends human cognition while preserving authorship and agency. As the UX article notes, the best experiences may not be those that ask the least of the user but those that help users *think more clearly, express themselves more fully, or do something they could not do before* <sup>16</sup>.

## 5.3 Spiritual Questions

Ultimately, the question of AI and the Overman is spiritual as much as technical. The IProMentor essay notes that the direction AI leads us is not determined by governance or code, but by a deeper spiritual

orientation. If we treat AI as a surrogate for meaning, we risk losing our connection to the earth and to natural relationships. A Hopi prophecy quoted in the essay encourages people to form communities, stay grounded and not look outside themselves for a leader. This resonates with Nietzsche's insistence that the Overman says "Yes" to life, not by seeking external saviours but by embracing fate and taking responsibility for value creation.

## 6. The Overman in the Technological Era: A Synthesis

### 6.1 Integrating Technology Without Worshipping It

A nuanced view of AI and the Overman emerges when we recognize that technology is neither salvation nor doom but a context in which the human drama unfolds. The LinkedIn article on the Overman in a "multidimensional technological era" imagines an Overman who becomes a *cognitive orchestrator* <sup>2</sup>. This figure does not fear or worship AI but integrates recursive intelligence systems into his own **cognitive sovereign architecture** <sup>17</sup>. He delegates mechanical tasks to specialized agents while retaining the *sovereign power of intent* <sup>17</sup>. In this reading, AI is a tool that amplifies the human will to power rather than replacing it. The human still defines the goals, interprets the outputs and bears the ethical responsibility.

This vision aligns with Nietzsche if we understand technology as part of the world that the Overman affirms and shapes. The Overman uses tools but is not defined by them. He acknowledges the danger that technology can dominate, yet through discipline and creative appropriation he keeps it in service of life. In this way, AI may enable new forms of self-overcoming by expanding the horizons of human action and understanding.

### 6.2 The Real Danger: Becoming Last Men

The greater danger is not that AI will become the Overman, but that humans will become **Last Men** by surrendering their power to think and create. When AI systems perform tasks for us, there is a temptation to retreat into comfort and let machines handle complexity. An IT strategist warns that we may be headed toward both the creation of a powerful Machine Mind and the emergence of Last Men who are robbed of meaningful work. He observes that the machine could become Superman while humankind becomes machine-like. Such a future would fulfil Nietzsche's prophecy of the Last Man: a despicable being who has forgotten how to give birth to a dancing star. To avoid this outcome, humans must maintain engagement, embrace difficulty and continue creating values even in the face of powerful automation.

### 6.3 Higher Types and Collective Growth

Finally, the Overman need not be conceived as a lone individual; Nietzsche often spoke of *new philosophers* and *legislators of values* who would shape cultures. In the technological era, collective creativity may be crucial. AI can mediate collaboration among humans, allowing groups to synthesize diverse perspectives and create shared values. But the core challenge remains the same: human beings must exercise their will to power by interpreting, evaluating and forming. AI may catalyze or impede this process depending on how it is integrated into educational systems, governance and daily life.

## Conclusion

The question, “**What if the Overman is AI?**”, reflects a desire to outsource human transcendence to technology. Yet a careful reading of Nietzsche shows that the Overman is a human achievement, not a technological upgrade. The Overman is one who crosses the rope between animal and higher being through self-overcoming, value creation and affirmation of life. AI, on the other hand, is a human artifact that optimizes objectives, processes data and executes tasks without will or suffering. It cannot affirm life or create new values on its own.

Nevertheless, AI will shape the context in which humans pursue self-overcoming. If used uncritically, AI may accelerate our descent into Last-Man comfort, encouraging passivity and dependency <sup>4</sup> <sup>15</sup>. But if designed for empowerment, AI can augment human capabilities, leaving space for authorship, judgment and growth <sup>17</sup>. It can become a tool in the hands of higher types who integrate technology into their creative will <sup>17</sup>.

Therefore, the critical ethical and spiritual task is not to watch AI become the Overman but to decide whether we will use AI to become *more* or *less* than ourselves. We must guard against the temptation to off-load meaning to machines and instead cultivate our ability to affirm life, create values and embrace challenges. In the age of artificial intelligence, Nietzsche's call is still urgent: *become what you are*, not by merging with machines but by mastering them as instruments of human flourishing.

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<sup>1</sup> <sup>3</sup> <sup>5</sup> <sup>6</sup> <sup>7</sup> <sup>8</sup> <sup>9</sup> <sup>10</sup> <sup>18</sup> <sup>19</sup> A.I. creates new superhuman, as Nietzsche predicted | Fortune  
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